



RESTORATIONESSENTIALS

Factory-Correct Restoration Reference

1969 Oldsmobile 442 Restoration Guide

Model Year 1969

Model	Oldsmobile 442 (Holiday coupe, Sports Coupe, conv.)
Platform	GM A-body
Engines	400 V8 (350/325 hp) / W-30 400 (360 hp) / W-31 350
Transmissions	Muncie 4-speed / Turbo Hydra-matic 400
Notable	Under-bumper Force-Air W-30; Hurst/Olds 455

Every specification in this guide was checked against factory literature, marque references, period road tests, and documented survivor cars. Where sources disagree or the record is silent, this guide says so rather than guessing.

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Chapter 1 — Oldsmobile and the 4-4-2 Idea

The digits arrived in 1964 — four-barrel carburetor, four-speed gearbox, dual exhausts — bolted to the Cutlass. For 1968 the 4-4-2 became a model in its own right, and 1969 is the second year of that standalone series: a facelift of the '68 car with the headlights drawn closer together and vertical taillights. Underneath, 1969 is the year of the 400 — one big-block in three factory tunes, a small-block W-car that cost more than the big-block one, and the Hurst/Olds sneaking a 455 past GM's cubic-inch limits for intermediate cars. Knowing which of those cars you actually have is the whole game, and it is decided by the VIN, the cowl tag, and the casting numbers — in that order.

Chapter 2 — What Makes 1969 Different

Three facts frame the year. First, the standard engine is the 400, not the 455 that headlines 1970: rated 350 horsepower with the manual transmission and 325 with the automatic — the difference is the factory tune, transmission-segregated and documented in period sources, not a misprint. Second, the W-30 breathes through dual scoops under the front bumper, not through a hood: the fiberglass hood belongs to 1970, and bolting one onto a '69 makes a tribute, not a restoration. Third, the W-31 — a 325-horsepower 350 small-block car — cost \$310, more than the big-block W-30 package at about \$263. Oldsmobile priced the small-block's hardware honestly; restorers should too.

Chapter 3 — VIN and Cowl-Tag Decoding

The VIN sits at the base of the windshield, driver's side, and follows the family pattern: **3** (Oldsmobile), **44** (the 442 series — the digits that separate a 442 from a Cutlass), body code **87** Holiday coupe / **67** convertible / **77** Sports Coupe, **9** for 1969, the assembly-plant letter (M Lansing, E Linden, Z Fremont; Oshawa-built cars come from Canada), and the sequential number. Since 1968 that sequential number is also stamped on the engine block and transmission case — the three stamps must agree on a matching-numbers car.

The cowl tag adds the Fisher Body story: ST69 and the body-style number (34487 on a Holiday coupe), the Fisher body sequence — assigned before the VIN and **not** expected to match it — trim code, paint codes, and the build date (12D = fourth week of December). A documented example: trim **930** is black vinyl bucket seats, and paint **75** in 1969 is Aztec Gold — note that paint codes are year-specific; 75 means something else in 1970. Some 1969 tags also carry option codes (D55 console, M21 close-ratio 4-speed appear on documented cars). Read the tag as the car's birth certificate for color and trim, then verify performance options against the hardware and the paperwork — neither the VIN nor the tag alone proves a W-30.

Chapter 4 — The 400: One Engine, Three Tunes

Engine	Rating	Torque	Notes
400 4-barrel (manual)	350 hp	440 lb-ft	Standard engine, stick tune
400 4-barrel (automatic)	325 hp	440 lb-ft	Standard engine, automatic tune
400 W-30	360 hp @ 5,400	440 lb-ft @ 3,600	Chapter 5
350 W-31	325 hp @ 5,600	360 lb-ft	Small-block W-car
400 W-32	350 hp	440 lb-ft	Cold-air package, milder tune
455 Hurst/Olds	380 hp @ 5,000	500 lb-ft @ 3,200	Chapter 7

The 400's restoration story is calibration honesty: a standard car with an automatic should not be 'corrected' to the 350-horsepower manual tune during a rebuild without documenting the change, because the rating difference is factory-original, not wear.

Chapter 5 — The W-30 Package in Depth

The 1969 W-30 (1,389 built; about \$263 on the sticker) is a system, and a correct car shows all of it:

- **Force-Air induction** — dual scoops beneath the front bumper feeding hoses to a sealed air cleaner. This is the 1969 system; there is no factory W-30 hood for this year.
- **'D' cylinder heads** (casting 400370) and a high-lift camshaft (328/328 advertised duration in period documentation), with a specially calibrated distributor.
- **Red plastic inner fender liners** — the lightweight W-car signature, shared with the W-31.
- **Heavy-duty radiator** and the rest of the cooling margin the cam demands.
- **Brakes follow the cam.** The W-30's low idle vacuum often mandated manual heavy-duty drum brakes from the factory — a 1969 W-30 with manual drums can be exactly as-built, where the same setup on a 1970 would be a question. Verify against the build paperwork, not against habit.

Body-style splits worth knowing: only 171 of the 1,389 W-30s were Sports Coupes — the pillared car drag racers preferred — and across the whole 1966–72 run, W-30 convertibles total just 666. Paperwork discipline from the 1970 guide applies double here: the W-30 premium rides on documentation.



Chapter 6 — The W-31 and W-32: The Small-Block W-Machines

The W-31 took the 350 small-block to 325 horsepower with ram-air induction and the W-car treatment, paired with the 4-speed — and at \$310 it cost more than the big-block W-30 package. Fewer buyers understood it then; restorers who skip it now miss one of the sharpest cars Oldsmobile built. The W-32 was the quiet one: the same cold-air package on a mildly tuned 400 at 350 horsepower, about 300 built. A W-32 is proven the same way as a W-30 — induction hardware, casting numbers, and paper — never by badges.

Chapter 7 — The Hurst/Olds

With GM still limiting intermediate cars' engine size, Oldsmobile shipped 442s to Hurst Performance for the 455 the factory line couldn't install: 380 horsepower, 500 lb-ft, 906 built for 1969, every one finished in Cameo White with Fire Frost Gold. There was no Hurst/Olds in 1970 — the year GM lifted the limit and the 455 became the standard 442 engine. Restoration note: the Hurst/Olds identity lives in its conversion paperwork and its unique equipment; the color scheme alone has been copied onto ordinary 442s for fifty years.

Chapter 8 — Transmissions: Muncie and Turbo Hydra-matic 400

Manual cars carry Muncie 4-speeds (the close-ratio M21 appears as a cowl-tag code on documented cars) or the heavy-duty 3-speed; console cars could carry the Hurst Dual/Gate with the Turbo Hydra-matic 400 automatic. As with 1970, the restoration sequence starts with the stamps: the transmission carries the VIN sequential, and that stamp — not the shifter on top — is the identity. Record every stamp before anything comes apart.

Chapter 9 — Axles, Brakes, Suspension, and Wheels

The Oldsmobile-built 12-bolt rear axle carries the Anti-Spin limited-slip; axle codes are stamped on the housing and the ratio is verified by counting rotations, never by trusting a 50-year-old gear set's reputation. Brakes demand the Chapter 5 honesty: standard cars, power-brake cars, and cammed W-cars left the factory in different configurations, and the cowl tag plus build paperwork — not the pedal feel of the last restoration — decides what belongs. Super Stock wheels were a factory option and are the period-correct visual anchor for the year.

Chapter 10 — Paint, Trim, and Factory Stripes

Paint codes are year-specific (Chapter 3's Aztec Gold warning). The 1969 presentation includes the striping that outlines the hood's power bulges and the pinstripe at the trunk edge, against the blacked-out egg-crate grille with silver slat edges. Before paint: photograph and measure surviving original striping wherever it survives, and hold the repaint to the cowl tag's codes — the tag outranks the color the car happens to wear today.

Chapter 11 — Production Numbers and Rarity

Model	Built	Notes
Sports Coupe	2,475	Pillared coupe
Holiday hardtop	19,587	The volume 442
Convertible	4,295	
Hurst/Olds hardtop	906	455, Ch. 7
W-30 (all bodies)	1,389	171 Sports Coupes
W-32	≈300	Hagerty estimate



Context for the W-30 number: the package ran 54 cars in 1966, 502 in 1967, 1,911 in 1968, 1,389 in 1969, and peaked at 3,100 in 1970. Rarity beyond these published splits — a color, a combination — cannot be verified from surviving factory records, and this guide does not print combination claims.

Chapter 12 — Rust-Prone Areas and Inspection Guide

A-body rust, A-body places: cowl and windshield frame, lower front fenders behind the wheels, rear quarters and wheel openings, trunk floor (rear-window and deck-seal leaks), floor pans, frame rails and body mounts at the rear. W-car additions to the walk: the under-bumper scoops and their hoses trap road debris against the core support, and the red liners hide the fender tops they bolt to — look behind them. Probe with a magnet and a light, photograph everything, and write it down before negotiating (Chapter 15).

Chapter 13 — Restoration Sequence for the 1969 442

- **1. Document** — VIN, cowl tag, all stamps, casting dates; look for the broadcast card before the interior comes out.
- **2. Name the car honestly** — standard 400, documented W-30/W-31/W-32, Hurst/Olds, or a car with questions. The answer sets budget and standard; badges set neither.
- **3. Disassemble by system**, bagging and tagging; 1969-only trim goes into labeled storage first.
- **4. Metal and frame**, then drivetrain to its documented tune (Chapter 4), paint to the tag, stripes from the photographs, trim to the tag.
- **5. Verify against the tag and the paper** at every step — not against the car in the next judging lane.

Chapter 14 — Engine Specifications at a Glance

Item	400 standard	400 W-30	350 W-31
Rating	350 hp (man) / 325 hp (auto)	360 hp @ 5,400	325 hp @ 5,600
Torque	440 lb-ft	440 lb-ft @ 3,600	360 lb-ft
Heads	Production	'D' (cast. 400370)	W-car small-block
Induction	Quadrajets 4-bbl	Force-Air, under-bumper scoops	Ram-air
Build	—	1,389	\$310 option

Chapter 15 — Buyer Inspection Checklist

- VIN reads 344 + body + 9 + plant; engine and transmission stamps match the sequential.
- Cowl tag: ST69, body style, trim and paint codes read and recorded; Fisher sequence not expected to match the VIN.
- W-30/W-31 claims: under-bumper scoops and sealed air cleaner, 'D' heads (400370) on a 400, red liners, paperwork — count what's present, price what's missing.
- No hood-scoop 'W-30' evidence accepted: 1969 W-cars breathe under the bumper.
- Hurst/Olds claims: 455, Cameo White/Fire Frost Gold, and conversion documentation — color alone proves nothing.
- Brake configuration checked against the engine's cam story before calling anything wrong.
- Rust map (Ch. 12) with photos, including behind the liners.



- Casting dates precede and sit close to the build date.

Chapter 16 — Casting Numbers and Date Codes

Same discipline as 1970: casting numbers name the part family, date codes place it in time, the VIN stamp ties it to the car. The 1969 W-30's documented anchor is the 'D' head, casting 400370; a correct date falls before the car's build week and near it. The 400-vs-455 question settles everything downstream: every standard 1969 442 left with a 400 (the 455 belongs to the Hurst/Olds), so a 455 in a standard car is an engine swap to document, not a rarity to celebrate.

Chapter 17 — Reproduction vs. Original: Tells That Matter

Under-bumper scoops, sealed air cleaners, and red liners are all reproduced. Original liners are aged and brittle at their mounting holes; crisp plastic is replacement until proven otherwise. Scoop and hose hardware carries period character reproductions approximate. None of this condemns a reproduction part — drivers need them — but an undocumented reproduction sold as factory-original is a misrepresentation, and the W-30 premium is exactly where that temptation lives. Document what you install.

Chapter 18 — Critical Fasteners: Sequence and Sources

As in the 1970 guide: this book does not print torque values it cannot trace to the factory page. It prints the discipline that makes the factory numbers work — threads chased and cleaned, lubrication as the manual specifies for the value in use, the printed pattern in at least three steps, and re-checks after the first full heat cycle where the manual calls for them. Take the values from the 1969 Oldsmobile Chassis Service Manual (Sources), and write what you used into your build sheet.

Recommended for this restoration

Shop exact-fit supplies on Amazon

- 1969 Oldsmobile 442 factory service manual
- Oldsmobile 400 engine rebuild kit
- Oldsmobile 442 W-30 reproduction parts
- 1969 Oldsmobile Cutlass 442 parts catalog

As an Amazon Associate, RestorationEssentials earns from qualifying purchases made through these links.

Sources Consulted

Every specification in this guide was checked against published references before printing. Where sources disagree, this guide says so in the text rather than picking a number silently. The references below are the backbone of the technical chapters:

- **Oldsmobile factory literature.** the 1969 Oldsmobile Chassis Service Manual and factory sales literature — the authority for torque values, specifications, and option codes



- **Hagerty valuation-tool model files.** factory-derived production splits and engine specifications for the 1969 4-4-2 series, W-30, W-31, W-32, and Hurst/Olds
- **Period performance press.** Motor Trend, Car Life, and Popular Hot Rodding test data as tabulated in marque spec compilations (musclecarfacts.com)
- **W-30 production history.** the year-by-year W-30 build record as compiled in marque coverage (autoevolution, 2025)
- **Documented survivor cars.** published cowl-tag decodes of real 1969 cars (AACA) and the 1965–71 Oldsmobile VIN pattern reference, used for tag formats and labeled as examples in the text

A note on numbers. Factory literature, period road tests, and marque historians do not always agree — production totals, horsepower ratings, and paint codes all have documented conflicts. This guide uses the best-supported figure in each case and flags the conflict where one exists, so you can judge for yourself.



Thank You

Thank you for choosing this RestorationEssentials guide. Whether this is your first 1969 Oldsmobile 442 or your fiftieth, you picked one of the great ones, and the fact that you are doing your homework before you turn a wrench puts you ahead of most of the field.

These cars survived because people like you refused to let them disappear. Every correct fastener, every properly decoded tag, every hour spent getting the details right keeps the history honest for the next owner and the next generation of enthusiasts.

The '69 is the connoisseur's 442 — one engine in three tunes, a small-block W-car hiding in plain sight, and a Hurst/Olds at the top of the page. You know how to tell them apart now, and that is most of the battle.

If this guide helped your build, we would love to hear about it. Good luck with the restoration, and enjoy every mile.

— The RestorationEssentials Team